Student Registration Number:	240171454
Module Code/Title:	GEO6805
Word Count:	2484
Date of Submission:	08/09/2025
Module Lead:	Dorothea Kleine

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Skills training as a route for empowering women: A report and recommendations for Kids Club Kampala

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27/08/2025

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Executive Summary

A report on Kids Club Kampala's skilling programme, which offers the chance for women in informal settlements to obtain a skill in tailoring or knitting to increase their economic opportunities. The research conducted revealed that the programme successfully facilitates the acquisition of a skill, increases pride and confidence, and enables community solidarity. Yet, challenges still remain, as explained by the women, including financial constraints, time poverty, domestic burden, and lack of governmental support. Long-term empowerment is therefore restricted, and emphasis on economic gains only should be avoided. Recommendations are presented at the end of the report to help tackle some of the challenges faced. This report stresses the importance of continuing a holistic bottom-up approach that utilises the community to foster sustainable development.

1. Introduction

1.1 Purpose and scope

This report was produced for Kids Club Kampala (KCK), to assess their skilling programme designed to provide women living in informal settlements with vocational skills, to further income generation and ensure financial independence. The report was done from June to July 2025, involving 15 interviews with women taking part in or graduates of the programme, and 1 focus group with 3 women who had graduated from the programme, and an interview with the project coordinator. The purpose of this report is to highlight the findings in relation to the programme's aims, analysing the strengths and challenges. To then demonstrate recommendations that can be implemented, which reinforce bottom-up community-focused approaches to continue a sustainable outlook on development and gender equality.

1.2 Kids Club Kampala

KCK is a Christian-based organisation working within Uganda to protect children and alleviate poverty through sustainable and community routes. The skilling programme is a part of the Family Strengthening division of the organisation, teaching knitting and tailoring, lasting four months, and receiving a certificate once graduated, which is recognised by the Directorate of Industrial Training in Uganda, and start-up equipment. All to provide business opportunities and further women's empowerment.

2. The issue

2.1 The importance of empowerment

Empowerment is widely thought to be a viable route to gender equality and poverty alleviation within development. A study done investigating definitions of empowerment by 49 international development organisations, by Oxfam, revealed there are six facets that foster empowerment: knowledge, agency, opportunity, capacity-building, resources, and sustainability, across five areas: health, economic, resource, political, and spiritual, interacting at organisational, community, and individual levels (Hennink et al., 2012). For

women living within informal settlements in Uganda, empowerment is essential to challenge the limitations restricting their lives.

2.2 Challenges of the mainstream approach to empowerment in development

Within the mainstream development narrative, due to the word's lack of agreed-upon meaning, empowerment becomes redundant, reduced to purely narrow economic measures. Development programmes tend to assume that if one aspect of female empowerment is ensured, it will lead to other aspects developing, such as increasing women's empowerment within society will result in greater welfare within the household (Anderson, 2022). But this approach ultimately leads to ignoring the real challenges and structural constraints the women face.

Therefore, analysing development programmes beyond an economic dimension is pivotal in understanding empowerment for marginalised women. For KCK, this community and relational aspect is clear, with a few recommendations to further improve against the barriers the women still face.

3. Report approach

This report utilises qualitative research done in the Naguru informal settlement in Kampala. The report used the research to understand how the women in the programme experience empowerment through lived experiences and how KCK could foster a further holistic and community-based approach. The report consists of four methods of collecting data:

- Interviews: 15 semi-structured interviews were conducted with the women currently in the programme or graduates.
- Focus Group: a group of 3 women who had previously graduated from the skills programme was conducted with collective reflection.
- Key informant interview: an interview was conducted with the programme coordinator heading the Family Strengthening division within KCK, to understand contextual and cultural ideas better, and the further challenges the programme faces.
- Observations: collected throughout the research process, including the women's graduation.

It was ensured that the interviews were done flexibly to work within the women's time and reduce disruption to their daily lives, and revealed many positives and challenges within the programme.

4. Key findings

4.1 Skill acquisition and increased income opportunities

The programme has achieved the main goal of enabling women to learn tangible skills that can increase their income opportunities. Many of the women described how, before entering the programme, they had nothing and no route for making money, but now they can obtain marketable skills to create products for income. Providing this support proves pivotal, with one woman stating:

> "I was like, no, I have to look for something that I can do with my hands, and I can do it myself. So that's why I joined here. I have so far starting earning income out of the skill." (Interview 10)

However, many women expressed a desire to learn new skills other than just tailoring and knitting, as they expressed that the more skills they acquire, the better their chances are of gaining an income source.

> "So, if Kids Club can add more programmes like hairdressing, computing, and baking."

The programme offers the opportunity for the women to look beyond just acquiring a skill. This demonstrates that the programmes focus on ensuring the women earn a skill that they can further develop, even once they have graduated, and increasing self-sufficiency by earning an income is key to developing women's empowerment. However, as the next finding will show, this is restricted by the barriers the women still face, and diversifying the skills available to the women would prove useful.

4.2 Barriers

Whilst the skill acquisition side of the programme was proven to be successful, there were many constraints described by the women that limited their empowerment. These challenges stem from external and institutional barriers rather than from the women's individual capabilities. One of these challenges is financial constraints, with many of the women depicting how they found it difficult to purchase the resources needed to continue with the programme, such as fabric:

> "It has been difficult, really has been getting the fabric and all that sort [...]" (Interview 3)

> "I am still behind because I missed out on some lessons because of a lack of fabric." (Interview 1)

Moreover, the women described how they faced domestic burdens that subsequently increased time poverty. One woman explained how her sister wanted to join the programme, but the issue was time and that she needed to work to earn money to support her family. Some family members and husbands were not being supportive of the women partaking in the programme. This can be attributed to the husbands observing that his wife is earning a small income, so he stops supporting her in all aspects and leaves all responsibilities to her, as the Project Coordinator explained.

Additionally, institutional limitations were evident, with a representative of the President of Uganda attending the women's graduation and giving a lengthy speech about all the programmes and money that the government offers for these women. However, the general sentiment from KCK staff was that these programmes and money are near impossible to access, and that due to political elections being soon, this was more likely a campaign opportunity. This further shows how, without institutional support and with a government utilising the struggles of marginalised women for their own political gain, real empowerment for women continues to be restricted.

This demonstrates a key finding, one that reveals that an increase in economic empowerment does not lead to true empowerment for the women if there is no structural change towards gender roles. This leaves the women who are a part of the programme struggling between pursuing income opportunities and increased domestic burdens, which aligns with the idea that women should not have to choose between 'bad alternatives', these women in informal settlements should be able to make the choices they want without fear of increased burdens in other aspects of their lives (Khader, 2018).

4.3 Aspirations and transformation

Beyond just skill acquisition, this programme has fostered an environment of deep personal transformations for the women involved. This key finding further reinforces the importance of emphasising a holistic approach to women's empowerment. This shift of mindset was evident in the women, transitioning from one of low self-worth and survival to one of pride, confidence, and active aspirations for their futures. The woman described wanting to start their own business, help other women learn skills, provide for their family, and achieve financial independence.

"My goals for the future are training others and helping other women" (Focus Group)

"This project has helped to give me confidence. In those days, I used to stay home. I felt so [...] depressed, but I no longer feel that way." (Interview 1)

This transformation proves pivotal in the women's empowerment journeys, as it creates a space for the women to oppose internalised oppression and see themselves as capable of real change, which goes beyond just income-generating opportunities. This finding demonstrates how the programmes' focus on providing an environment for this change to occur is key for empowerment, and highlights how empowerment cannot be constricted to narrow economic outcomes, but rather as a continuous process.

4.4 Community solidarity

A powerful finding from the research was that there was an essential sense of community solidarity produced from the programme. The women described how they quickly came together and formed a support network through emotional and financial support. This was evident through the desire to help other women and transfer knowledge, sharing fabric and materials, and providing emotional support.

"You think like sometimes you may face something, challenges may come in life, and you think like, maybe my life is ending here, but when you join heads together, you find a solution [...]" (Interview 10)

One woman described an important example of a bottom-up collective approach to empowerment that can be expanded on by KCK in the recommendations section of this report:

> “When one has no material, you can help, I can give her my fabric for today, and then the other day, when I don’t have she can give me also.” (Focus Group)

Beyond the programme, the women explained how they had joined women's community banking groups within the informal settlements, where there is support through loans, resisting the structural barriers they face. This, alongside the powerful solidarity among the women, rejects the neoliberal mainstream development agenda that promotes individuality and productivity, and provides a key finding for KCK to continue to foster the long-term sustainability of the programme. It additionally offers a more culturally situated lens to look at empowerment through, which emphasises holistic community-based bottom-up approaches to empowerment, but also development.

5. Conclusions

This report has laid out the impact of KCK’s skilling programme on the women’s lives, presenting their lived experiences of empowerment and community solidarity. As the key findings demonstrate, the women successfully acquire a skill, increase their chances of income, and emotionally transform. Nevertheless, empowerment should not be reduced to just individual transformations and economic metrics, as barriers were still faced, such as financial constraints, domestic burdens, time poverty, and lack of governmental support. Therefore, this report shows why a holistic approach ensures long-term sustainable impact for the women and highlights the need to continuously foster community ties and utilise a bottom-up approach to development.

6 Recommendations

Upon considering the key findings of the research, the following recommendations are highlighted to further the long-term impact of the programme and continue fostering empowerment for the women.

6.1 Create a community material pool

- **What?** A pool of material for the women taking part in the programme, which could be supported by donations from local churches and businesses, and additionally, a separate pool created by the women in the programme, empowering them to manage their collective resources.
- **Why?** This would help to reduce the limitations of resources experienced by the women and provide a sustainable and bottom-up approach. It offers a collective problem-solving approach to the limitation and provides an opportunity for the women to help each other.
- **How?** Reach out to local churches, businesses, and local leaders, and explain how the lack of materials due to financial reasons results in women missing lessons or avoiding joining the programme and ask for any donations they would be able to give.

6.2 Strengthen graduate support networks

- **What?** A yearly reunion for the women who have graduated from the course, with the opportunity to catch up and offer advice.
- **Why?** The women expressed a desire to share knowledge with one another and emphasised how transformative the connections they formed together. It would provide a space for the women to share their achievements and celebrate together, offer business advice, and continue talking about the challenges that they still face. This makes sure that the long-term impact of the programme is continued and reinforces the support systems created by KCK.
- **How?** Use the Naguru skilling centre to host the reunion instead of hiring somewhere to lower the costs. Contact the previous graduates, and if proving difficult, utilise other graduates, as they may be able to contact certain women.

6.3 Offer a peer-to-peer mentoring opportunity

- **What?** Offer the opportunity for graduates to return through a mentoring scheme to provide them with the choice to teach other women, as that was a main desire for a lot of the women.
- **Why?** This will reinforce the bottom-up community approach by facilitating community knowledge transfer. Additionally, it will further the women's confidence as it validates their expertise and gives them a valuable experience.
- **How?** Firstly, identify the graduates who have showcased a high level of tailoring or knitting skills, as well as leadership qualities. Women who desire to teach others could apply through a potential formal application process, and the criteria for this should not just be focused on skill level, but also a passion for helping others and emotional intelligence. By offering this, KCK can nurture a long-lasting impact for the women in the programme.

6.4 Provide a range of different skills

- **What?** KCK could expand on the vocational skills offered in the programme, with suggestions from the women for courses in baking, hairdressing, and computing.
- **Why?** Diversifying the skills recognises that women have varied interests, and if there is an opportunity to learn a skill they are more interested in, then they will be more passionate and motivated. Importantly, if every woman is taught tailoring or knitting, there becomes an oversaturation of women with this skill in the community, lowering their opportunity of finding income.
- **How?** Firstly, KCK could ask the women what other skills they would be most interested in learning. Secondly, women within the community who are skilled in these different areas should be approached to become potential teachers, as this reinforces a community approach. Lastly, run workshops to trial different skills and test out what is popular and whether they run smoothly.

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